



FOREWORD

Dedicated to My Parents

From a small personal list to a living devotional collection - and now, a home on the web.

Some journeys begin with a grand vision.
This one did not.

It began quietly, with something very small and very personal: a simple list to keep prayers, mantras, hymns, bhajans and other devotional works organised and easier to find.

Then I thought of my mother.

Her faith has always been a deeply rooted part of her life. I thought that if I could organise these devotional works in a way that made them easier for me to find, perhaps the same collection could make things a little easier for her too.

That one simple thought changed the direction of everything.

From my mother, my mind went to my family. And from my family came another question:

Why should it stop with us?



WHY IT GREW

There must be countless people searching for the same prayers, the same hymns and the same sacred words their parents and grandparents once knew by heart.

There must be elderly people who remember a prayer from their childhood but no longer know where to find it. There must be parents who want to pass something meaningful to their children but do not know where to begin.

There must be younger generations who are curious about the traditions they have inherited, yet find those traditions scattered across languages, books, recordings and places that are not always easy to discover.

And there must be families, like mine, simply trying in their own way to remain connected to something precious that can slowly become distant with the passing of time.

That is when a personal list began to become something more.

The purpose was no longer simply to collect. It became an attempt to preserve, organise, connect and make accessible a small part of an extraordinarily vast spiritual and cultural inheritance.

What began as a few devotional works slowly grew into prayers, mantras, stotras, bhajans, kirtans, aartis, sacred texts, regional traditions, saints, temples, festivals, pilgrimage traditions, devotional music and many other expressions of Hindu faith from different parts of India.

FROM THE BOOK TO THE WEBSITE

Then the collection grew beyond the pages of a book. It found another home on the internet.

The Hindu Devotional Collection website was created so that these materials could become easier to search, read, listen to, explore and share. What once required turning through thousands of pages can increasingly be discovered through a search. Sacred scriptures and books can be brought closer to the reader. Devotional music can be explored. Prayers and works can be searched, and useful devotional tools can sit alongside the collection itself.

<https://ashishbharani.github.io/devotional/>

The website is not separate from these books. It is another chapter of the same journey.



THE PURPOSE HAS NOT CHANGED

The technology may have changed. The purpose has not.

If an elderly person is able to rediscover a prayer remembered from childhood...

If a mother or father is able to share a hymn with their children...

If a young person discovers something here that creates curiosity about their roots...

If someone finds a scripture that they had always wished to read...

If a family hears an old bhajan together and, for a few moments, remembers someone who once sang it at home...

If a person sitting alone somewhere finds a prayer that gives them a little comfort...

then every hour spent building these books and this website will have been worthwhile.

Because this collection is not about numbers. It is not about how many pages it contains, how many works have been catalogued or how large the website becomes.

It is about connection.

Connection with faith. Connection with memory. Connection with family. Connection with the generations who came before us. And perhaps, in some small way, connection between those generations and the ones that will come after us.

BETWEEN REALISM AND FAITH

Much of the spirit behind this entire work comes from the two people to whom I owe far more than words can properly express - my parents.

From my father, I learned the value of hard work, discipline, perseverance and the responsibility of trying to do something properly once one has chosen to undertake it. His outlook has always carried realism and practicality - the understanding that good intentions mean little unless they are supported by effort.

From my mother came something different, but equally important: faith. Through her, I came to understand the quiet strength people can draw from devotion - the comfort of prayer in difficult moments, the hope it can give when answers are not easy to find, and the peace that sometimes comes simply from placing one's faith in something greater than oneself.



Somewhere between my father's realism and my mother's faith, this collection found its direction.

***One taught me to keep working.
The other taught me why the work might matter.***

Perhaps that is why something that began as an exercise in organisation slowly became a labour of love. And perhaps that is why I have found it difficult to ever call it "finished."

A LIVING COLLECTION

Traditions such as ours cannot truly be contained within a final page. They have travelled for centuries through scriptures and temples, through saints and scholars, through music and festivals, through villages and cities, through grand ceremonies and quiet household prayers.

But perhaps most importantly, they have travelled through people: from grandparent to parent, from parent to child, from teacher to disciple, from one home to another. Sometimes through a manuscript. Sometimes through a book. Sometimes through a song. Sometimes through nothing more than someone remembering a few lines that were once heard in childhood.

Today, technology gives us another way of carrying those memories forward. A book can become searchable. A prayer can be heard from thousands of kilometres away. A forgotten work can be rediscovered. A scripture that once required travelling to a library may now be opened from a phone. And a collection that began on one person's computer can potentially reach a home that its compiler will never see.

That possibility means a great deal to me.

I know this collection will never be perfect. I know errors may sometimes remain despite every effort to avoid them. I know there will always be genuine works still waiting to be discovered, traditions deserving better representation, links that change, information that can be improved and knowledge that remains beyond what I have been able to find.

So I hope this never becomes a monument that simply sits still. I hope it remains a living collection - something that can continue to grow, be corrected when necessary, and become richer whenever another genuine work is discovered or another lesser-known tradition can be responsibly documented.

The website makes that continuing journey possible in a way the original list never could.



PASS IT FORWARD

Yet however large the collection becomes, however many pages are added, and however much the website evolves, I never want to forget how all of this began.

*It began with one small list.
Then came the thought of my mother.
Then my family.*

And finally came the hope that perhaps something created within one family could travel quietly beyond it - from person to person, from home to home, from one generation to another - until it reached people whose names I may never know.

I may never know who opens these pages. I may never know who visits the website late at night searching for an old prayer. I may never know whose childhood memories are awakened by a bhajan found here. I may never know which child discovers a scripture for the first time, which parent shares something from this collection with their son or daughter, or which person finds a prayer here at precisely the moment they needed one.

And perhaps I do not need to know.

Because if somewhere, in some home, this work helps even one person reconnect with their faith, their family, their memories or their roots, then it has already travelled farther than I imagined when I first began.

*Use it. Explore it. Share it. Improve it where it can be improved.
And above all, pass it forward.*

From one person to another. From one family to another. From one generation to the next. Because our heritage remains alive not merely when it is preserved - but when it is passed on.



TO MY PARENTS

For the values you gave me,
for the discipline that taught me to continue when the work became difficult,
for the faith that taught me why such work can have meaning,
for everything you quietly gave me long before this collection ever existed,
and for being the reason that a very small idea eventually found a much larger purpose -

***I dedicate this entire endeavour to you,
with all my love, respect and gratitude.***

These books began because of you. The website grew from that beginning. And whatever this collection may become in the years ahead, a part of both of you will always remain within it.

May something that began within our family find its way into many more.

May an old prayer be remembered. May a forgotten tradition be rediscovered. May a parent find something worth passing to a child. May a child someday pass it further.

And if, somewhere along that journey, this work brings even a little faith, peace, remembrance, curiosity, comfort or devotion into someone's life - that will be blessing enough.

With Pranam,

Ashish Bharani

Collector & Compiler | Hindu Devotional Collection

[Visit the Hindu Devotional Collection](https://ashishbharani.github.io/devotional/)